

party alliance is capable of making cracks in vote-banks of both the BJP and the Congress. The alliance with the Left will also help the BSP shrug off the doubts among the minorities that it is heading for a post-poll alliance with the BJP. This will null the lead that the SP-Congress combine had over the tactical voting pattern of Muslims.

By cosyng up with the Left, Mayawati has also earned enough lung power to counter a fresh affidavit filed by CBI in the disproportionate income case. "The CBI is being used to switch off or switch on its investigation and prosecution and launch cases just at this moment according to what will help the ruling party to rig up a majority," said CPI General Secretary Bardhan.

Also on the chopping block is Mandal politics which once pivoted the north Indian electoral alliances. The new combine is capable of pulling the rug from under OBC-centric politics and promote a new brand of political equation based on

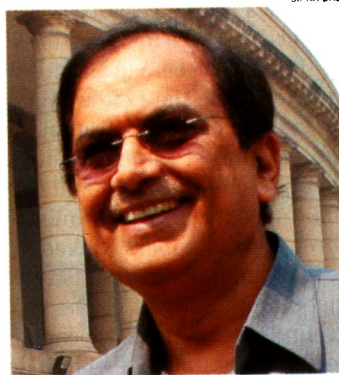
in cow-belt by tying up with the BSP. The Red brigade can also hope to compensate for seats it may lose due to anti-incumbency factor in its traditional bastions by winning a few seats in Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Andhra Pradesh and Bihar. On a clear day, the alliance is capable of winning hundred-plus seats across the country.

The idea of projecting a Dalit prime minister, which carries tremendous symbolic value, has given sleepless nights to both the BJP and the Congress. "The UNPA is a misguided missile, directionless. It is a vehicle incapable of taking any message anywhere," says Congress spokesperson Jayanti Natarajan. "In its desperation to topple the Manmohan Singh Government, the Left saddled Mayawati on the prime ministerial horse without realising that this 'horse' is more dangerous than the horse-traders," Shiv Sena leader Bal Thackeray commented in the editorial published in the party mouthpiece, *Saamna*.

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



SIPRA DAS



KEY PLAYERS:
(From left)
Mayawati,
Akhilesh Das,
A.A. Dumpy,
Satish Mishra

The alliance with Left will help the BSP to shrug off the doubts among the minorities that it is heading for a post-poll alliance with the BJP. This will null the edge that the SP-Congress combine had over Muslim votes.

caste determination, regional priorities, minorities and smart social engineering.

The BSP as a political party has also grown beyond Uttar Pradesh and is capable of swinging votes in at least 10 states, including Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Punjab. It is aiming at bagging at least 80 seats in an ambitious expansion spree. When the BSP rode to power last year winning 206 of the 403 seats, it had leads in 55 of the state's 80 parliamentary constituencies. Mayawati camp says that it can be a crucial player in another 60 seats outside the state.

In states like Karnataka, it could open its mark and help the JD(s) to enhance its performance. The Left will also revive its isolated pockets

Mayawati, on her part, went on to accuse the BJP and the Congress of teaming up to prevent her from becoming the prime minister: "It is clear from the trust vote that both Congress and BJP do not want the 'daughter of a Dalit' to become the prime minister of the country."

For the cadre-based party like the CPI(M), dealing with individual-centric party like the BSP may also prove dearer. The party also fears that due to its alliance with the BSP, it will end up losing its residual cadre to the bigger partner. The Left movement across the Hindi belt had suffered severe erosion whenever it joined hands with major national players like the Congress and the SP. It is at the risk of watching history being repeated. ■